



YOU ARE **37 WEEKS AND 4 DAYS**

17 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

What exactly triggers the start of labor is still a mystery. Does the signal come from your own body or does the baby play a part in the decision? Every labor is different, and the timing of your first labor can be quite different from your second.

“ Gradually, each of your baby’s bones is becoming strengthened thanks to adequate amounts of calcium. ”

Your baby’s bones are strengthened by the process of ossification in which hard bone is formed from calcium. To meet this increase in demand, you absorb calcium much more readily from your diet.

By this stage of pregnancy, the baby’s humerus in the upper arm, femur in the upper leg, and tibia in the lower leg have undergone this process. As ossification occurs at specific weeks in your pregnancy, ultrasound scans can use these as markers to estimate the date of the pregnancy, if necessary.

The time at which this ossification occurs may be seen a few days earlier in girls than boys and, interestingly, the patella (knee bone), does not ossify until after birth.

ASK A DOCTOR

I’ve had a small amount of bleeding. Should I be concerned? Bleeding in late pregnancy is common and usually not harmful to your pregnancy. However, you should always let your doctor know if you are having any bleeding, and you will need to be seen by an obstetrician to confirm that there are no serious concerns.

Serious causes of bleeding include placental abruption, when the placenta separates from the uterus wall. A low-lying placenta can also cause painless vaginal bleeding. A sticky mucousy discharge, which is often tinged with blood, is called “[bloody show](#)” and may indicate labor is starting (see [The “bloody show”](#)).

BACH FLOWER REMEDIES

Flower essence blends are designed to calm and center your energy, which some think can help you relax and encourage you to focus. Rescue Remedy and Emergency Essence, types of Bach Flower Remedy, are thought by some to be effective when used in labor, and in the weeks prior to and after the birth. The remedies are taken for a variety of symptoms, including anxiety, shock, worry, stress, or simply for a boost during a long or painful labor.